

2026 Comparative Politics Comprehensive Exam

Day 1: Core

Ryan Gibbons
University of Chicago
Department of Political Science

August 22, 2026

Question

What array of causal drivers are adduced in the literature to account for different political outcomes in regime type, state form or electoral systems (i.e. dictatorship vs democracy; contrasting cleavage structures; electoral systems). How do theorists deploy history and timing in making their arguments?

Introduction

From the peninsula of Gibraltar,¹ one can see land governed by three distinct states: the Kingdom of Spain, the Kingdom of Morocco, and the United Kingdom.² The landscape is visually quite similar; the boundary between Gibraltar and Spain is purely political, and the seven-mile-wide strait is geologically little more than an advanced valley. Yet, each of these lands has experienced dramatically distinct transitions – or lack thereof – from monarchy to democracy. Spain’s development to liberal democracy famously included an extensive fascist dictatorship; the United Kingdom’s gradual progression to the current Westminster System was significantly more gradual; Morocco is still a monarchy today, even if with some modest constitutional restrictions. Why, then, does this one coastal viewpoint offer such a distinct range of political outcomes across a relatively undistinctive physical landscape?

Identifying political and economic deviations across meager physical boundaries is not a novel perspective within political science or the social sciences more generally; Acemoglu & Robinson (2012) famously employ this framework to counter theories of economic dependence on geographical factors in “Why Nations Fail.” Yet, the question is still an intriguing one that has motivated a significant corner of the social sciences, perhaps none more significantly than comparative politics. By Mill’s (1843) “method of difference,” the relatively identical nature of this physical landscape, compared to the significant variation in sociopolitical outcomes, suggests that the causal factors behind regime outcomes must lie elsewhere. If geography alone does not sufficiently explain the distinction between the human-created institutions

¹So long as one’s southward view is not entirely obscured by the titular Rock

²Of which Gibraltar is an “Overseas Territory”

built upon them, then it indeed must be the case that the driving factors are, to a large extent, humanistic themselves.

In this response, I explore the literature's fundamental discussions of the factors driving political outcomes in regime type, state form, and broadly, political institutions. There are many more such mechanisms than could reasonably fit in this response, at least without seriously sacrificing depth; the exclusion of any given factor (for example, cultural origins of political legitimacy) in no means precludes its existence. I instead present two primary causal arguments, each of which is unique in its approach but not mutually exclusive from the other: (1) a state's historical economic composition and structure, including the chronology of those developments; and (2) the identity-based composition of the constituency, along with the salience of those identity characteristics. I further present a relatively – though not entirely – conflicting counterargument regarding the innate dependency of political outcomes on exogenous influences, discussing both its limitations and its possible contributions nonetheless. I conclude by reflecting on the value of historical analysis in explaining contemporary political phenomena, and suggest how its practice may be most effectively incorporated into the field. In discussing and evaluating these arguments, I do not intend to provide a definitive weighting of their relative accuracy or value. To do so would be more than I could hope to reasonably accomplish in an entire career, and would almost certainly involve discarding valuable arguments that may indeed be foundational. Yet, I do explore my own perspectives within these frameworks, largely built upon my personal affinity towards rationalist and institutionalist answers. It is our responsibility as social scientists to pursue those narratives which we believe most effectively explain the world around us, and to consider how those mechanisms might be best employed to construct a more effective political future.

An Economic Explanation

One of the field’s driving discussions of political evolution is the role of economic structures and factors. Scholars of this framework broadly posit that the development of contemporary regime types (and the political institutions within them) are a result of the historical amount, distribution, and nature of capital. Yet, the exact ways in which these economic contexts affect long-term political outcomes are quite varied within the literature.

I organize this section into three subsections based on the role of the respective socioeconomic classes: the elites, the middle class, and the poor. A significant component of this literature ties economic structure to ultimate regime type, be that stable democracy, communism, or authoritarianism; as a result, a great deal of this section discusses democratization as a primary dependent variable. Yet, this is far from the only outcome impacted by economic development. As we will see, the evolution of phenomena such as property rights and proportionalist legislatures – both central components of governance – are further influenced by these arrangements.

The Elites: A Power-Sharing Balance

The evolving role of the elites in political development is, to say the least, curious. Historical social orderings generally included an exclusive elite with much greater influence in social, political, and economic affairs than their middle-or-lower-class counterparts. Yet, liberal democracy invokes norms of “representativeness, accountability, equality, and participation” (Lijphart 1991), inherently opposed to the existence of a disproportionately-influential class.

This suggests that an ultimate transition to liberal democracy must involve a transition away from this influence; likewise, an inability to facilitate this transition will likely result in some alternative outcome. There subsequently exist two driving relationships between the elites and political outcomes: the ability of the elite to gain power from the crown, and the decision of an empowered elite to yield additional influence to the lower and middle classes.

Let us first consider the seminal work of Barrington Moore, whose (1966) “Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy” explores (among other topics) the role of the elites in differentiating between democratic, fascist, and communist outcomes. Moore delineates between two general arrangements of the aristocracy: a dependence on the state, or a dependence on the market. If the aristocracy’s wealth was primarily derived from the state – be that sharing in its political rents, employment or appointment to prestigious posts, or similar dependencies – the state would accordingly possess an excess of influence over this class, frequently leading to royal absolutism. This, in turn, largely prevented any transition to even infantile democracy: either the state was powerful enough to retain its absolute authority, or the elites would be empowered to revolt and establish an extractive regime framed by (Boix 2003) as “right-wing authoritarianism.” Conversely, as Moore posits, a power-sharing equilibrium between the crown and the elites was an early prerequisite for later democracy and could facilitate both the peaceful coexistence of the regime and the elites, as well as a peaceful graduation of influence to these aristocrats. Yet, to Moore, these are merely preconditions of further political development, which itself will be motivated by the yeomen and/or the lower classes.

Of course, it is important to consider not just the conditions leading to the enfran-

chisement of the elite, but also the instigating factors which facilitated this development. A common answer is simply informational – that the elites possess privileged information which the state does not. (Ahmed & Stasavage 2020) discuss the emergence of council governance – the first movements away from total executive authority, providing the elites with constrained political authority – as a reflection of informational asymmetry whereby the elites could extract revenue from the land (and the people) much more efficiently than the state. Indeed, they find support for this hypothesis as it pertains to agricultural production, whereby councils were historically more likely to emerge in societies with significant variability in caloric production. In a more contemporary setting, this information “solution” is further adopted by autocrats; (Gandhi & Przeworski 2007) present this dynamic as one reason (of many) for autocrats to employ non-homogenous legislative and bureaucratic institutions. Indeed, the informational explanation is an important one, and we will revisit it when discussing the role of the peasantry.

However, this framework is countered by a broad literature on coercion and “buying off” the elites. In many cases, states faced a meaningful incentive to at least partially enfranchise the elites either to secure economic stability or avoid the aforementioned violence. The most notable contribution to this dynamic is almost certainly (North & Weingast 1989), who explore the expansion of property rights and political constraints following England’s Glorious Revolution. The relative absolutism of the state, they argue, presented two critical obstacles to economic development:

1. Because the state could viably seize or exploit private property, there was limited incentives for the elites to actually invest in private property (and therefore generate capital);

2. Because the state had previously been prone to renege on loans and bonds, there was limited incentives for the elites to invest in the state and its affairs (again primarily through loans and bonds).

At its core, North & Weignast argue, this created a commitment problem that could only be overcome if the state could credibly constrain its future ability to exploit, seize, and renege. Facing this challenge, the state indeed binded itself both through specific guarantees regarding property rights and through a broad transfer of authority from the Crown to the Parliament, whose quasi-elected nature granted some degree of meaningful political influence to the elites. A related line of reasoning indeed explores the extension of the franchise as a means of avoiding revolution from the disenfranchised. Aemoglu et al’s aptly named (2000) “Why Did the West Extend The Franchise?”, though primarily employed to explain the later inclusion of the middle and lower classes within the political realm, can absolutely be applied to this initial enfranchisement of the wealthy as well: the state (here, the initially-enfranchised body) may avoid revolution by further including these elites. In fact, the credible threat posed by the wealthy (and its resultant impact on authoritarian decay) is not just defined by their capacity for violence, but further by their ability to impact the state’s economic structure. In addition to the elite’s ability to exploit the aforementioned informational asymmetry, (Boix 2003) stresses the role of the mobility of their own capital in gaining meaningful representation. Under this theory, more mobile capital (technology, trade, etc.) could be easily moved abroad and therefore rid the state of its taxable revenue, while less mobile capital (namely land) did not lend such a threat. This relationship of credible threat is further formalized by (Clark, Golder & Golder 2017)’s exploration of the

“Exit, Voice, or Loyalty” framework, whereby the exploitation of the state is limited by the citizen’s ability to “exit” (in a variety of ways, albeit all costly to the state) the political system.

Now, let us consider the second mechanism discussed above: the elite’s decision to, once empowered, extend enfranchisement to the middle and lower classes. (?) presents this as a central puzzle in democratic development, whereby the holders of power, influence, and wealthy often decided to acquiesce some degree of it. Here, we are orbiting a central theme of the literature on the historical role of the wealthy in contemporary political outcomes: the role of an organized elite in developing (or failing to develop) democratic institutions. (Ziblatt 2017)’s answer to his aforementioned puzzle posits the establishment of an organized conservative movement representing the interests of the elites as a critical factor in a peaceful transition to democracy. This resultant protection, he argues, is a defining factor in achieving either liberal democracy or conversely autocracy. Interestingly, Ziblatt’s argument deviates from the earlier framework of tension between the elites and the state, and instead focuses on tension between the elites and the middle-and-lower classes. If the elites can protect their interests and assets to some degree, a peaceful transition to democracy becomes much less costly for them, and may very well be a tolerable transition. Conversely, if the elites do *not* enjoy this political coordination, the violent seizing of power by the middle-or-lower classes becomes significantly more likely, and with it a reign of left-wing authoritarianism and drastic redistribution (a la (Boix 2003)).³

³This provides yet another explanation for the differentiation of political development between Britain and Spain; while the British elites and upper classes ultimately gained political consolidation and representation, the Spanish elites were unable to achieve a similar level of unity particularly in the shadow of early-20th-century Spanish nationalism. The impact of this differentiation can be clearly seen in their divergence in the 1950s, where Britain remained a powerful liberal entity while Spain veered into a right-wing fascist regime.

The transition from autocracy to a purely-elite democracy⁴ is by no means a final transition within political development, but it is a crucially important one: without this first extension to a restricted democracy, we instead can expect to see a dramatic transformation into various flavors of authoritarianism. Clearly, the ability of the elites to form an organized and credible threat against both the state and the lower classes has a meaningful influence on later political distinctions. To that end, both Ziblatt and Acemoglu & Robinson provide convincing arguments that the decision of the elites is pivotal in democratization. Yet, this is only one piece of the puzzle, and their relevancy above the middle and lower classes is certainly not assured.

The Middle Class: “No Bourgeoisie...”

By far, the most defining work on the role of the middle classes in political development comes from (Moore 1966), who ultimately posits: “No bourgeoisie, no democracy.” Through this lens, and building on similar logic as the role of the elites, the empowerment of the middle and middle-upper classes created an economic vehicle which could secure political enfranchisement from the state. Much of this comes from his delineation of a market-versus-state-dependent aristocracy, further extended to include the middle classes: in the presence of an effective market from which the wealthy and the “yeomen” could extract wealth, opportunities for abuse by the crown became limited, and the market itself grew larger. Yet, it was the transition of these yeomen from collective to private ownership, and in particular the vast expansion of middle-class wealth following the commercialization of agriculture, that in turn fueled further development.

⁴More appropriately, a large oligopoly

The reason for this transition again involves the credible commitment of the middle classes against both the elites and the state (often at the same time). As (Moore 1966) further explores, the growing influence of the yeomen – and the resulting tensions between this class and the crown as their wealth grew – ultimately required some form of political concessions. Most prominent among these was the emergence of the modern Parliament, which originated as a “committee of landlords” particularly intended to satisfy this group.⁵ The argument is once again matched closely with Acemoglu et al (2000), whereby the growing power of the middle classes ultimately extracted enfranchisement from the elites in an effort to avoid revolution.

But, just as with the elites, we must not only consider the ability of the middle classes to become empowered, but their willingness to share that power with the lower classes and expand the democratic franchise. Boix (2003) provides a straightforward explanation: the middle class will support a transition to democracy if and only if their income is below average, such that they can expect to be net recipients of democratic redistribution. This may indeed be enough to support an initial transition to full democratization, if the franchise consists of the elites and the middle classes and we hold true the assumption that the middle classes are larger than the elites. Yet, whether or not this new democracy can be maintained is itself a function of a more critical analysis of the role – and position – of the middle class. Such is explored by Iversen & Soskice (2019), who combine this framework with the median voter theorem in order to argue that the sustainability of a democratic regime is dependent on *who* the median voter actually is. This lens suggests that a middle-class median voter will

⁵Note that this necessarily precedes the further expansions of Parliamentary authority as discussed by (North & Weingast 1989), but does present a somewhat intriguing dichotomy. Though the British Parliament’s origins were to satiate the yeomen, a significant amount of influence was held by the elites. Some of this is reflected in the gradual transition of authority from the House of Lords (which directly represented the elite) to the House of Commons (which more broadly represented the yeomen).

likely support capitalistic endeavors and subsequently self-sustain a liberal democracy with a market economy. Yet, conversely, if the median voter is poor, the transition to democracy may not come with a self-enforcing market economy (which itself may threaten the democratic future).

The Lower Classes: Organization and Cross-Class Cooperation

At last, we must consider the distinct role played by the lower, and how its various formations drastically impacted political outcomes. Here, we can first introduce Dahl (1972), who identifies peasantry as the outcome of agrarian societies under hegemony (the alternative being “free farmers” under polyarchy). To understand the role of the lower and peasantry class in the development of modern states, we must subsequently consider what facilitated (or failed to facilitate) this development of inclusiveness, and which of Dahl’s two paths it followed: from closed hegemony to polyarchy, or from closed hegemony to inclusive hegemony.

Let us begin with the first of these questions, which can be broadly characterized as a response to new wealth. Through some form of development – technological progressions, discovery of new resources, or a slew of other possibilities – a society can quickly gain wealth. As Huntington (1968) argues, it is precisely this newfound presence of economic capacity which facilitates a desire for political change; unrest cannot survive in total abject poverty. The impact of this new wealth on the political status of the poor can be clearly seen under two possibilities. First, suppose that the new wealth is broadly enjoyed directly by the poor. Though this process alone is rather rare, the result is a peasantry class who now desire – and can likely extract – political inclusion. More commonly, though, suppose that the poor are

largely or entirely excluded from this new wealth. Subsequently, the potential gains of seizing power or inclusion by force become greater, while the costs remain static.

This is precisely the logic presented by Acemoglu & Robinson (Acemoglu & Robinson 2001), who in turn offer a convincing explanation to the second question above (which path of inclusiveness actually occurs). Under this framework, as the wealth held by the elite grows relative to that held by the poor – a calculation influenced both by present welfare and by inequality – the opportunity costs the poor face from revolution become drastically less significant. In such cases, a violent expansion of participation will likely result in Dahl’s “exclusive hegemony,” characterized by high participation but low public contestation. Conversely, in the lack of sufficient motivation for revolution, either slow democratization or general staticity may be expected. Yet, what if the peasantry is sufficiently motivated to pursue change, but not organized enough to launch a meaningful revolution?⁶ Once again, Moore (1966) provides a meaningful explanation: because a powerful peasantry can viably pursue revolution, it is precisely when the peasantry is disorganized or ineffective that a peaceful transition can instead be achieved *if an intentional effort to alleviate this lack of representation is pursued in the meantime*. This again begs Huntington’s (1968) model of political development, in that the order and timing of transition become critically important for whether we can expect peaceful democratization or violent, unpredictable revolution: if the economic growth of the peasantry precedes its political inclusion, we can expect violence, unrest, and inclusive hegemony, but if political development can precede (or even keep pace with) this economic expansion, a more orderly pathway can instead be achieved.

⁶I’m saving much of my collective action literature for tomorrow, but there’s a wealth of opportunity here.

Identity Structures & Cultural Cleavages

We have now extensively explored the impact of economic substance on political outcomes, most specifically regime type. Yet, another line of literature focuses on the role of identities, cleavages, and group formation in shaping the political landscape. Though quite different from the (incredibly positivist) characterization of economic influences, this discussion is absolutely a valid and meaningful framework in evaluating development.

In this section, I first explore how these constructions of identity can meaningfully impact the context upon which political systems are built, including when such cleavages may be more or less salient. I then discuss the institutional responses to these contexts, and the resultant policy outcomes we might expect under their influence. Note that while the previous section focused primarily (though not exclusively) on regime type as a dependent variable, the most relevant outcome observations here are more apt to involve the specific makeup of a given regime type (that is, types of democracy or dictatorship).

Cleavages and their Salience

Societies can be largely delineated along a series of cleavages: race, ethnicity, religion, political belief, and a myriad of others. Yet, the outcome of these cleavages is far from uniform: some result in ostensible cooperation, while others result in seemingly insatiable violence. Therefore, except in the case of absolute homogeneity, an exploration of political development must include some consideration of which cleavages matter, and when.

For this, we can first turn towards Lipset & Rokkan (1967) exploration of cleavages

within political parties. They establish three preconditions to a social cleavage to become politically salient:

1. Empirical basis: There must exist some sort of identifiable way to distinguish groups based on the cleavage, such that some individuals can be included and others excluded;
2. Normative element: There must exist some shared identity or ideals such that the division between the included and excluded can be legitimized;
3. Organizational expression: There must exist some degree of groups, parties, or other institutions which can mobilize and subsequently represent the in-group.

These conditions allow us to begin considering when underlying cleavages might become politically salient, and indeed, later applied work largely supports these prerequisites. Two core examples are Posner (2004) and Fearon & Laitin (2003). In the former, Posner rejects previous theories of salience as a “given” such that well-established cleavages would necessarily result in violence; he instead finds that these cleavages alone are *not* sufficient to support violence, and that some other instigating factor (generally group size) must instead be invoked. In the latter, Fearon & Laitin similarly demonstrate the lack of a direct tie between ethnic/religious diversity and the prevalence of civil war, finding that when controlling for income, enhanced diversity and clearer cleavages are not necessarily more likely to result in violence. From a standpoint of establishing order and peace, these are both productive conclusions: we need not pursue absolute homogeneity in order to achieve stability. Yet, both papers continue to suggest that while significant cleavages may not directly cause instability, they are likely to “fuel the flames” when other divisive factors are present.

Notably within these flames lies economic inequality and the developments extensively

explored in the first major section of this response. As new wealth was developed and/or inequality dramatically changed, the resultant political transformations could indeed be influenced by cleavages, including those along class lines. Moore (1966), for example, highlights the relationship between the three primary classes as a driving factor in determining either a peaceful transition to democracy or a more violent transition to authoritarianism. Under his framework, democratic transitions required both (1) the elimination of the aristocracy as an independent class (possibly by means of its fusion with the bourgeoisie) and (2) avoiding a coalition between the peasants and the aristocrats, which would likely prevent the moderating forces of the middle class from retaining meaningful influence. Huntington's (1968) contribution just two years after Moore's *Social Origins* provides a similar framework while clarifying the ties to underlying cleavages; he outlines a "Green Uprising" whereby a struggle for power between the urban elites and some rural cohort is followed by a coalition between other (significantly more moderate) urban and rural sectors. In these cases, the classes themselves may exist as cleavages, and the development of the coalition which ultimately imposes stability may itself be identity-based as well.

Yet, cleavages are not singular, nor do they exist in isolation from each other. Rather, existing scholarship has identified two primary collections of pluralistic cleavages: reinforcing, and cross-cutting. Lipset & Rokkan (1967) provide a key characterization of this divide, identifying cross-cutting cleavages as those which further divide existing cleavages, while their reinforcing counterparts are largely along already existing cleavages. As they discuss, the result of these two arrangements can have dramatic impacts on social outcomes. Cross-cutting cleavages tend to further fragment society and political parties, and create a great

deal of cross-pressurization amongst voters who may be subject to conflicting influences. In particular, Dahl (1972) directly examines cross-cutting cleavages as potentially threatening to polyarchy, as they may further dampen efforts to create enough unity to support broad participation.⁷ Conversely, reinforcing cleavages may create less drastic fragmentation, but instead deepen the polarization between cohorts on either side of that cleavage.⁸

Stability Under Cleavages

Given, then, that we have some predictability of when cleavages will become more or less politically salient, how has the political landscape evolved in response? We can broadly consider two “strategies”: limiting the negative effects of identity conflicts within political systems, and limiting the salience of those conflicting identities themselves. We will begin by focusing on the first.

To pull again from Huntington (1968), order is a foundational prerequisite for political development: if peace, prosperity, and liberty is to be achieved in the future, we must secure political control. Yet, order among warring factions is a particularly difficult outcome to achieve. Let us first consider a very simple cleavage, partitioning society into two distinguishable groups. The resulting political system faces one of two challenges: either the groups

⁷Note that the lack of an organized peasantry further reflects the development of the Moroccan economy and its subsequent (relative) avoidance of political turmoil, at least compared to its Arabic neighbors and 19th-century European counterparts: the geographic isolation of the Moroccan peasantry, as well as its ethnic heterogeneity and linguistic cross-cutting cleavages, inhibited any such organization as would be considered by Moore (1966) to endanger a peaceful transition.

⁸Interestingly enough, Dahl also contributes to this side of the debate as well – polyarchy is supported in part when contestation is high, and contestation may be lowered by reinforcing cleavages. Perhaps the more comprehensive interpretation is that any cleavages are obstacles to polyarchy, but that the mechanism of this hindrance is dependent on whether the cleavage is cross-cutting or reinforcing.

are so evenly empowered that broad coordination between the cohorts (and therefore, order) cannot be achieved or sustained, or one group enjoys more power than the other. We are subsequently presented with what appears to be an initial choice between Hobbes' state of nature, whereby life is "nasty, brutish, and short" for all (Hobbes 1651), or a tyranny of the majority, whereby life is nasty, brutish, and short for some (Madison 1787). Presuming neither of these to be particularly representative of good governance, the institutional challenge subsequently becomes inclusion and order without dominance.

Perhaps the most significant discussion regarding political structures and identity groups lies within the debate between majoritarian and proportional democratic systems.⁹ As Lijphart (1991) delineates, majoritarian government can be considered as being *by* the people, while proportionalism is instead *for* the people. More tangibly, majoritarian systems empower the ruling body – be it the cabinet, president, or ruling party – to act decisively and with minimal obstacles. Though this may encourage certain forms of legislative efficacy and efficiency, the framework exists precisely because it nearly-summarily eliminates the influence of the opposition (Lijphart 1991, Powell 2000). If cleavages are clear and salient – and particularly if they are reinforcing, such that a clear "in" or "out"-group can be identified – the ruling group may often use its majority to abuse, repress, or otherwise extract from their counterparts (Lijphart 2012, Powell 2000, Abizadeh 2021). This forms the basis of a broadly-recognized result in electoral politics: majoritarian systems provide minimal protections for minority groups. However, this is not to say that majoritarian systems can only be effective in limited scenarios with relative homogeneity. Notably, there exists legitimate evidence conflicting with the conclusion that majority rule necessarily results in abuse of authority,

⁹Assuming, of course, that the system itself is democratic, though we can relax that assumption later.

most notably presented by Kasara's (2007) *Tax Me If You Can*. Her analysis of African executive leadership conversely suggests that an identity group's executive empowerment may instead result in disproportionate *in-group* exploitation, as the leader becomes more empowered to extract from their peers relative to their opponents. This by no means disproves the potential harms of majoritarian systems in highly-fragmented contexts, but does suggest further nuances within this relationship.

There exists a similar line of reasoning within this realm focused on the relationship between cleavages, trust, and political outcomes. Strictly held identity-based cleavages may absolutely be expected to increase tensions between groups and, in many cases, create a sense of distrust. Whether this be derived from stereotypes about other groups' character, historical experiences, or even active conflict, the resulting distrust has a commonly negative impact on political efficacy. Consider, for example, Putnam's (1993) foundational work on the role played by social capital in the effectiveness of democracy and civil society. This social capital facilitates productive interactions between sometimes-conflicting political actors, and promotes a more stable, bureaucratically-capable democratic regime. Yet, social capital itself is a function of trust: in communities of deep distrust, including that sown across identity lines, social capital can become significantly more sparse. Putnam indeed finds present social capital and democratic effectiveness to be highly correlated with historical factors of trust, both in local institutions and in fellow citizens (including those across identity lines). We might subsequently expect that unmitigated polarization resulting in distrust has a meaningful – negative – effect on the ability to maintain highly-functioning democratic institutions and legitimately productive bureaucracies.

Yet, while distrust may absolutely be a common outcome of group divisiveness, there may exist possibilities for productive cooperation to facilitate *even more* trust and social capital than would have been possible previously. For this, let us again consider Dahl (1972), who emphasizes the interdependency of public contestation and trust. A ruling group will become significantly more likely to permit legitimate contestation if they have reasonable trust in the opposition to (1) not abuse their leadership and (2) not reshape future electoral institutions; to that end, developing trust between opposing groups may be a core component of delivering a highly-desirable polyarchy. The reverse effect is also quite plausible: a group who facilitates a fair and peaceful transition of power – especially when reciprocated such that the “two-turnover” condition is satisfied – will almost certainly gain significant trust from their counterparts. This is not to suggest that deep entrenchment among identity lines will inherently build political trust – absent effective institutions or good actors, it will likely not – but is to imply that these distinctions *may*, if responsibly governed such that this trust can be developed, produce a more effective democratic and bureaucratic landscape than would otherwise be possible.

Endogenizing Identity

So far, we have taken the existence – and salience – of these identity cleavages as a given. In many cases, their entrenched nature may imply such a conclusion – yet, in reality, a range of actions and environmental contexts may exist which can subsequently influence both the construction and relevance of these group delineations.

Let us first consider the role of nationality and nationalism. Anderson (1983) famously

refers to these national communities as being “imagined,” insofar as an exogenous delineation of the group is unclear and the majority of nation members will never interact with each other. This constructs an entire dimension of identity which can be shaped, manipulated, and employed by citizens, leaders, and political opportunists alike. Political actors may place their own definitions upon the “nation” and further build their own narratives regarding what that nation represents and stands for; they may accordingly construct entire identities and cleavages that would otherwise be far from obvious. There exists a clear range of employment of such constructed nationalism; for example, contemporary European far-right parties have almost ubiquitously embraced a highly-exclusive conception of the nation, its people, and its values. Yet, the question is not merely *how* to construct the nation, but rather, *how much* to emphasize its salience.

It is precisely this question – and its application to state stability – which Penn (2008) explores. In Penn’s model, there exists a tradeoff between national and ethnic identity, such that a leader facing an ethnically heterogeneous population may instead attempt to substitute their ethnic identity with nationalism (and therefore minimize the impacts of such ethnic cleavages). The salience of ethnic identification is subsequently largely tied to (1) the distribution of wealth within society, including the relative inequality between ethnic groups, and (2) the institutional distribution of political influence across the various ethnic groups. The result is an endogenized approach to identity and its salience, whereby the ruler may gain – or sacrifice – stability by adjusting the distributions of wealth and political power between constituent groups. It is precisely this endogeneity that aptly concludes our discussion on identity and political outcomes, as political actors may not only experience these impacts

but further exploit them for their own gain.

A Tangential Explanation: Exogeneity

The above sections have discussed highly logical and intentional approaches to institutional development, and rightfully so – an outcome occurring “by chance” is not a particularly convincing argument. Yet, there is a degree of exogenous influence that absolutely may affect the observed political landscape, and it would be unwise to negate their influences. I discuss two core exogenous mechanisms here: a survival effect, and foreign influence.

Let us first consider a “survivalist” hypothesis of democratic development, primarily explored by Przeworski et al (2000). Their specific mechanism is an application of the relationship between democracy and economic development – namely, that democracies are much less likely to survive economic tumult than autocracies, and therefore the relationship between democracy and wealth is merely observed because poorer democracies did not survive (or stay democratic). This is an incredibly compelling mechanism amongst a rich directional debate, but it further suggests another framework for evaluating the present political landscape: that those phenomena, institutions, and arrangements we can observe are those which either (a) were not subject to exogenous shocks or (b) were more resilient to those exogenous shocks. Whether (a) or (b) holds true is of particular interest in determining various developmental pathways, and it is furthermore particularly difficult to isolate. We are slightly aided here in probability theory, which suggests that over a long enough period of time there should be some convergence in the occurrence of truly random events – in expectation, England is hit by no more meteorites per square meter than Spain – but in reality, we hardly have a sample

of human history large enough to meaningfully compare exogenous effects.

A second – and perhaps more compelling – mechanism is that of foreign influence. Without question, domestic politics can be heavily dependent on external factors. Though there are undoubtedly infinite ways in which global activities might affect a given political environment, Dahl (1972) outlines three distinct pathways: (1) affecting domestic beliefs, (2) affecting decision sets available to domestic actors, or (3) imposing political landscapes outright. Gourevitch (1978) provides a similar exploration of foreign impacts on domestic political landscapes, focusing on means instead of degree. He delineates two forces of international affairs on domestic politics: the distribution of international power (in turn, war) and the distribution of international economic activity (in turn, trade). This literature yields a broad range of mechanisms, from subtle behavioral influences (which may or may not be intentional) to political domination, yet the various impacts are clear. The institutional environments of Eastern Europe, for example, were extremely influenced by the Soviet Union during the manifestation of Communism; their institutional environments today are extremely influenced by threats of Russian expansionism. Therefore, while it may not be the most compelling answer for scholars of comparative (or, to borrow from Scott Gehlbach, “domestic”) politics, the influence of exogenous and foreign influences cannot be ignored.

A Comprehensive Overview: Historical Comparativism

Having explored these various connections between situational context and political outcomes, we have engaged significantly with analyses of historical evidence. To some extent, this link between environmental factors and political outcomes is necessarily rooted in historical

reasoning, even if just tautologically; political development takes time, and so if we are to understand even present phenomena, we must look towards the past at varying lengths. Yet, more broadly, the literature surveyed in this paper suggests a significant dependence on using historical analysis to explain contemporary politics. I conclude this paper by discussing the many benefits of this approach, as well as its limitations, and how future scholarship could best employ historical and time-dependent arguments to appropriately characterize political development.

One of the central – if not obvious benefits to this format of analysis lies in the *possibility* of certainty over outcomes. (Note that this does NOT imply certainty over causes, which I explore below.) With some meaningful frequency, in the wake of historical developments we can make distinct factual claims about the *observed* contexts and *observed* outcomes. Taking North & Weingast (1989), for example, we have very little doubt of either the existence of low investment prior to the relevant reforms or the existence of those reforms themselves: they are documented, explicit, and broadly uncontested. Not only that, but within a relatively concise period of time, they are also final: pending some absurd revelations, our understanding of the outcome of this post-reform period is unlikely to meaningfully change. Both of these traits – certainty and finality over outcomes – can be difficult to come by in purely contemporary environments. We are not sure, for example, the ultimate effects of Brexit on 21st-century European politics, and indeed those effects may change: perhaps economic gains from regulatory independence are truly delayed by eleven or more years. It is of course difficult to establish clear bounds on this line of reasoning; four centuries of indirect effects absolutely connect early British property reforms with modern governance. But, a

focus on historical contexts allows for a degree of stability over outcomes that may be fleeting when events are unfolding.

This discussion of finality deserves further discussion as well. Ziblatt (2017) in particular emphasizes the importance of focusing on long-term outcomes and trends rather than immediate or cross-sectional evaluations. The motivation for this, he claims, is simply the relative instability of political arrangements over extended periods of time: intertemporal variations can otherwise lend misleading or incomplete conclusions. To a large extent, this is particularly relevant when considering institutional resilience and survivorship effects such as those proposed by Przeworski et al (2000), as our ability to learn about a phenomenon's resilience from its survival alone grows over time. Perhaps one of the greatest examples of this on the reading list¹⁰ is in Huntington's (?) characterization of political development in the Soviet Union. Huntington repeatedly cites the USSR's seemingly inevitable survival as a reflection of its highly developed institutions, which per his model preceded economic development and therefore could curb internal unrest. Yet, Huntington's words are now far closer to the fall of the Soviet Union than we are today. Had Huntington been granted the benefit of hindsight we now enjoy, such that his analysis was instead primarily historical, he undoubtedly would not have placed such emphasis on the stability of a now-defunct state, and very likely could have constructed different conclusions about the role of individual liberty on long-term stability and order.

Finally, it is without doubt that excellent historical comparativism influences our modern perceptions of politics and institutional arrangements: a phenomenon occurring

¹⁰Despite my absolute love for the rest of his model

centuries ago does not negate its explanatory power within modern politics. North and Weingast represent a cohort of 20th-century scholars who both redefined the field's collective understanding of political institutions and founded their work largely on historical contexts. Again without too heavily extending into the institutions-specific literature in this first response, these contributions to political analysis were significant despite (or even because of) their historical rootings. North & Weingast's 1989 paper is of course a prime example of developing contemporarily-applicable understandings of political dynamics in exploring the state's perpetual commitment problem; their 1999 paper with Paul Milgrom on the evolution of the Medieval law merchant further provides a foundation for scholars of institutional endogeneity and collective action without repeated interactions despite its rooting in archaic contexts (1990). North and Weingast are, of course, exceptional practitioners of this methodological framework, but their successes lend credibility to the practice of historical comparativism as a whole.

That being said, the historical approach is not without its drawbacks. Just as I referenced its finality above, it places significant limits on our ability to collect additional data and form interpretivist arguments. Data collection can be particularly difficult when significant time has passed since the targeted phenomena occurred, and is further influenced by the administrative and recordkeeping practices of historical civilizations and actors. Perhaps more importantly, historical lenses limit our ability for follow-up inquiries when the actors whose reasoning we seek are no longer alive to provide or clarify it. For example, it could be illuminating to acquire more specific details of the decisions made by 17th-century British elites to provide greater loans to the state, and could further allow us to rule out alternative

causes – for example, perhaps informational advancements made reneging more difficult – that might be best explored by direct inquiry. This is particularly difficult in attempting to advance any interpretivist theories, as the information available is finite.

This challenge can ultimately be related to our above discussion of historical certainty: while historical analysis may yield greater certainty over *outcomes*, it may not be as productive in providing certainty over *causes*. A thorough and factually complete historical analysis regarding political activities can provide us with a distinct set of circumstances and a distinct outcome, but may not identify a unique connection between the two. This is not to imply that such a narrowing of explanations is without use. For instance, Elster (1990) presents a similar drawback to formal models whereby rationalist theories can return multiple explanations, but argues that this narrowing of most-plausible mechanisms can still be valuable for the social sciences, as it can both redirect from implausible arguments and provide “starting points” for further examination. Yet, it remains a defining limitation of historical theory-building: we are not guaranteed (and indeed may rarely secure) a unique answer.

What, then, is the most appropriate way to consider historical evidence and factors in contemporary social science? The “easy” answer is to satisfy the needs of all of the above – to secure sufficient historical evidence to solidify claims of causation. This, of course, is not a particularly fair answer to the question, and the question as a whole would be largely moot without informational constraints. Rather, we must identify pathways to replicating the phenomena in contemporary contexts and evaluating whether or not these theories based on historical evidence can be forward-applied. This may be particularly fruitful in developing economies and emerging political systems whose arrangements of power and influence could

closely reflect such historical notions. For example, while we are limited in the additional evidence we can gather surrounding North & Weingast's original scenario, we may find developing countries whose economies are presently burdened by property rights limitations that can instead yield comparative results. We are not merely tied to the situational context; rather, it can be worthwhile – and even optimal – to explore the target phenomena in modern circumstances. A common argument against Nordic social policies is that the high taxation hinders investment and generation of capital; a similar analysis of credible constraints against excessive taxation (and the requisite economic impacts) may provide a novel application of the original theory. The opportunities are nearly boundless, and though the restrictions of this form of analysis and interpretation are many, their complementation with a well-rounded rationale of contemporary evidence can indeed provide a foundation for good, meaningful, and productive social science.

References

- Abizadeh, Arash. 2021. "Counter-Majoritarian Democracy: Persistent Minorities, Federalism, and the Power of Numbers." *American Political Science Review* 115(3):742–756.
- URL:** https://www.cambridge.org/core/product/identifier/S0003055421000198/type/journal_article
- Acemoglu, Daron & James A. Robinson. 2001. "A Theory of Political Transitions." *American Economic Review* 91(4):938–963.
- URL:** <https://www.aeaweb.org/articles?id=10.1257/aer.91.4.938>
- Acemoglu, Daron & James A. Robinson. 2012. *Why Nations Fail: The Origins of Power, Prosperity, and Poverty*. New York: Crown Business.
- Acemoglu, Daron, James Robinson, Pranab Bardhan, Steven Durlauf, Jeffrey Frieden, Ed Glaeser, Claudia Goldin, Peter Lindert, Torsten Persson, Dani Rodrik, John Roemer, Kenneth Sokoloff, Peter Temin, Jaume Ventura & Michael Wallerstein. 2000. "Why Did the West Extend the Franchise? Democracy, Inequality, and Growth in Historical Perspective." *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 115.
- Ahmed, Ali T. & David Stasavage. 2020. "Origins of Early Democracy." *American Political Science Review* 114(2):502–518.
- URL:** https://www.cambridge.org/core/product/identifier/S0003055419000741/type/journal_article
- Anderson, Benedict. 1983. *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism*. New York: Verso.
- Boix, Carles. 2003. *Democracy and Redistribution*. New York: Cambridge University Press.
- Clark, William Roberts, Matt Golder & Sona N. Golder. 2017. "The British Academy Brian

- Barry Prize Essay: An Exit, Voice and Loyalty Model of Politics.” *British Journal of Political Science* 47(4):719–748.
- URL:** https://www.cambridge.org/core/product/identifier/S0007123416000442/type/journal_article
- Dahl, Robert A. 1972. *Polyarchy: Participation and Opposition*. New Haven: Yale University Press.
- Elster, Jon. 1990. “Norms of Revenge.” *Ethics* 100(4):862–885.
- URL:** <https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/10.1086/293238>
- Fearon, James D. & David D. Laitin. 2003. “Ethnicity, Insurgency, and Civil War.” *American Political Science Review* 97(01):75–90.
- URL:** http://www.journals.cambridge.org/abstract_S0003055403000534
- Gandhi, Jennifer & Adam Przeworski. 2007. “Authoritarian Institutions and the Survival of Autocrats.” *Comparative Political Studies* 40(11):1279–1301.
- URL:** <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414007305817>
- Gourevitch, Peter. 1978. “The Second Image Reversed: The International Sources of Domestic Politics.” *International Organization* 32(4):881–912.
- URL:** <http://www.jstor.org/stable/2706180>
- Hobbes, Thomas. 1651. *Leviathan or The Matter, Forme, and Power of a Commonwealth Ecclesiasticall and Civil*.
- Huntington, Samuel P. 1968. *Political Order in Changing Societies*. New Haven: Yale University Press. Chapters 1, 4, 5, 6 assigned.
- Iversen, Torben & David Soskice. 2019. *Democracy and Prosperity: Reinventing Capitalism through a Turbulent Century*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.
- Kasara, Kimuli. 2007. “Tax Me If You Can: Ethnic Geography, Democracy, and the Taxation

- of Agriculture in Africa.” *American Political Science Review* 101(1):159–172.
- URL:** https://www.cambridge.org/core/product/identifier/S0003055407070050/type/journal_article
- Lijphart, Arend. 1991. “Constitutional Choices for New Democracies.” *Journal of Democracy* 2(1):72–84.
- URL:** <https://access.heinonline.com/HOL/P?h=hein.journals/jnlodmcy2&i=72>
- Lijphart, Arend. 2012. *Patterns of Democracy: Government Forms and Performance in Thirty-Six Countries*. 2nd ed. New Haven: Yale University Press. Study materials filed under the 1999 1st-edition folder.
- Lipset, Seymour Martin & Stein Rokkan. 1967. Cleavage Structures, Party Systems, and Voter Alignments: An Introduction. In *Party Systems and Voter Alignments: Cross-National Perspectives*, ed. Seymour Martin Lipset & Stein Rokkan. New York: Free Press.
- Madison, James. 1787. *Federalist No. 10*.
- Milgrom, Paul R., Douglass C. North & Barry R. Weingast*. 1990. “The Role of Institutions in the Revival of Trade: The Law Merchant, Private Judges, and the Champagne Fairs.” *Economics & Politics* 2(1):1–23.
- URL:** <https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/abs/10.1111/j.1468-0343.1990.tb00020.x>
- Mill, John Stuart. 1843. *A System of Logic, Ratiocinative and Inductive*. Vol. I New York: Harper & Brothers. Chapter 8, Volume I assigned; orig. pub. 1843.
- Moore, Barrington, Jr. 1966. *Social Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy: Lord and Peasant in the Making of the Modern World*. Boston: Beacon Press. Chapters 1, 2, 4, 5, 7–9 assigned.
- North, Douglass C. & Barry R. Weingast. 1989. “Constitutions and Commitment: The Evolution of Institutions Governing Public Choice in Seventeenth-Century England.”

The Journal of Economic History 49(4):803–832.

URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2122739>

Penn, Elizabeth Maggie. 2008. “Citizenship versus Ethnicity: The Role of Institutions in Shaping Identity Choice.” *The Journal of Politics* 70(4):956–973.

URL: <https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/10.1017/S0022381608080997>

Posner, Daniel N. 2004. “The Political Salience of Cultural Difference: Why Chewas and Tumbukas Are Allies in Zambia and Adversaries in Malawi.” *American Political Science Review* 98(4):529–545.

URL: https://www.cambridge.org/core/product/identifier/S0003055404041334/type/journal_article

Powell, G. Bingham, Jr. 2000. *Elections as Instruments of Democracy: Majoritarian and Proportional Visions*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Przeworski, Adam, Michael E. Alvarez, Jose Antonio Cheibub & Fernando Limongi. 2000. *Democracy and Development: Political Institutions and Well-Being in the World, 1950–1990*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Putnam, Robert D. 1993. *Making Democracy Work: Civic Traditions in Modern Italy*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Ziblatt, Daniel. 2017. *Conservative Parties and the Birth of Democracy*. New York: Cambridge University Press.